that match – a non-Test playing side beat us down to pulp. I was caught for 2 off 4, trying to play a stupid shot. Still, I got my first wicket in the World Cup: the Bangladesh captain, Amin-ul-Islam – bowled for 15. The gloomy Pakistan batting figures can always be looked up, but what I went through that day cannot.

We had just got off the bus in Northampton and were heading to the dressing room. There was a huge crowd, mostly Asians, surrounding us. When I heard a bunch of guys shout: 'Pakistan is definitely losing today!' I couldn't locate who said it, but considering our form in the tournament till then, the comment didn't make any sense. I thought it was ridiculous. But those words stuck with me, both for the tone in which they were said, and especially in the light of the outcome of that game. We lost by 62 runs. It was that stray comment from a bystander which planted the seeds of doubt in my mind. Something seemed a bit odd.

Since 1998, there had been chatter that a match-fixing inquiry was required for Pakistan players. Now, after that World Cup game against Bangladesh, it became clear that something nasty was developing. I would find out later via reports in the press that our odds, according to legitimate bookies in the UK, were 33:1. However, there had been no reports about unusual betting in the UK. Instead, this was the first time I got to hear about the South Asian and Middle East bookie circuit – all illegal and underground, and a whole different world of betting.

The revelations were intense and disturbing. Here I was, just a lad in this great game, in this great team, fighting to win the greatest tournament of all. And here was this underworld, functioning and alive, beneath my very feet. It was unsettling. I was confused.

I remember during that tour, in the dressing room, we were all very driven and focused. We were hard on ourselves when we lost. We worked hard when we practised. The best of us used to scold ourselves when we underperformed. With the kind of dedication and sweat, blood and tears that would go into every game, it never occurred to me that some of us might have turned into sellouts, that too at the highest level of the sport.

What is even more strange is the way we bounced back in the tournament. At Nottingham, we met the other green giant, South Africa. Both sides were leading their respective World Cup groups. I was dropped, again – the inconsistency of the selectors was ridiculous at this stage – but was among the lucky ones to see one of the greatest matches in World Cup history. The match went down to the wire. Moin bhai's searing 63 destroyed Allan Donald's spell in the death overs and the game went the Proteas way on the last ball of the penultimate over when Saeed Anwar dropped Lance Klusener.

And then, it was time to take on India.

The battleground was Manchester, almost like a home turf for us. With the two nations' defence forces engaged in combat in Kargil, this wasn't any ordinary India–Pakistan face-off. We were aware of the stats: India had won all their previous games against us in World Cup history. Skipper Mohammad Azharuddin wanted to be part of the third such victory – the only Indian to do so at the time. He played that game like a man possessed, smashing a stellar 59 off 77 balls. Tendulkar was in his element. Dravid fired on all cylinders (I would catch him off Wasim bhai, but not before he put an incredible 61 runs on the board). As for our batting, Saeed bhai stood his ground till 36, but I went early, as did most of the top order. Inzi and Moin bhai put up a brave stand, but the pressure on us by then was so high, we had probably begun to worry about vandalism on the streets and flags burning back home. Though we would lose by 47 runs – and